Notes From Underground Cedar Performance Viewing Guide

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Notes from Underground — Viewing Guide

Performance: Larry Cedar, *Notes from the Underground* (YouTube), about 1 hr 32 min
Paired with: the Literature & Philosophy lecture on *Notes from Underground* as an existentialist text

All timestamps refer to the Cedar video. Cedar uses the older Garnett translation, so wording differs from the lecture's translation (for example, reason is "one-twentieth" of life here rather than "one-twelfth"). Quotes follow the transcript; obvious speech-to-text errors are corrected in [brackets].

What Cedar leaves out

The adaptation omits several passages the lecture relies on:

- Dostoevsky's framing footnote and closing editor's note
- Reading as escape, the "sauce" passage, and "hero or wallow in the mud"
- The stone wall and the man of action
- The Civil War and bloodshed argument
- The bullied school friend
- **The Crystal Palace**

The closest substitutes are noted in the relevant sections below. To discuss the Crystal Palace itself, hand out a short printed excerpt from the text.

Quick index: the performance in order

Time	Moment	Theme
1:30	"I'm a sick man… I'm a spiteful man"	Opening, spite
2:37	Spiteful official; the officer's sword feud	Petty malice, revenge
4:37	"neither a hero nor an insect"	No stable self
6:40	Consciousness is a disease	The intellectual
7:06	Sinking into the mire; pleasure in degradation	Sublime & beautiful
10:04	The toothache	Passive-aggressive suffering
12:58	Can't even be lazy	No stable self
13:41	The Enlightenment argument	Being rational
15:35	Reason vs. will	Being rational
18:22	Piano keys	Crystal Palace substitute
19:03	"How do you know… it is desirable to reform man?"	Being rational
21:35	Every man has things he won't admit	Confession
23:17	"a story… of the falling snow"	Part two begins
24:20	The "strikingly intelligent" face; the fly	Intellectual, fear
25:18	The grandiose daydream	Dreaming
26:40	Visit to Simonov; inviting himself	Self-humiliation
32:34	Memories of school	Biography
36:05	The farewell dinner	Revenge, humiliation
42:03	The Prince Kolya barb	Petty malice
45:21	Pacing table to stove for three hours	Shame
49:46	Pursuit and revenge fantasy	Revenge
54:38	No one there; "saved from death"	Can't follow through
57:32	Liza	Love
59:16	The sermon to Liza	Power, love
1:09:59	The student's letter	Liza's dignity
1:13:19	Dreaming of being Liza's savior	Dreaming, love
1:14:28	Apollon and the wages	Petty power
1:18:30	Liza arrives	Love
1:20:18	The outburst: "I wanted to humiliate"	Revenge, power
1:24:36	"she understood it all"; love as tyranny	Love
1:26:11	The five-ruble note; running after her	Integration
1:28:32	Corrective punishment	Confession
1:29:15	"better in books"; begging for control	Integration, control
1:29:53	"relax the control and .. we should [beg] to be controlled again"	Control, Crystal Palace
1:31:33	"I don't want to write more from underground"	Ending

1. Framing: confession, readers, courage

- **The confession premise** (21:35–22:23): "every man has reminiscences which he would not tell to everyone… there are other things which a man is afraid to tell even to himself… I want to try to experiment whether one can even with oneself be perfectly open and not take fright at the whole truth."
- **The reader paradox.** He addresses "ladies and gentlemen" throughout, then brushes them off (4:16–4:30): "are you not fancying… that I am expressing remorse… I can assure you I do not care if you are."
- **Cowardice vs. courage** (34:51–35:01): "even in the acutest paroxysm of cowardly fever I dreamed of getting the upper hand of dominating them."
- **Confession as self-punishment**, not literature (1:28:39–1:28:47): "it's hardly literature as much as corrective punishment."
- **The ending.** Cedar has no editor's note. He ends on the narrator's own line (1:31:33): "I don't want to write more from underground."

For discussion: Is confessing his cowardice a kind of courage, or a way of claiming superiority ("at least I admit it")?

2. Structure

- Part one runs to about 23:00. The shift into the story is marked at 23:17–23:22: "and so let it be a story… of the falling snow."

3. Who he is (biography)

- **Clerk, inheritance, and corner** (5:16–5:45): "I am a Collegiate Assessor… a distant relation left me 6000 rubles… I immediately retired… my room is a wretched horrid one on the outskirts of town."
- **Staying in Petersburg he can't afford** (5:53–6:08): "it is very expensive to live in Petersburg… but I'm remaining in Petersburg."
- **Orphan** (1:02:30–1:02:38): "I grew up without a home; perhaps that's why I've turned out so."
- **School, excelling to escape mockery** (33:15–33:37): "to escape from their derision I made all the progress I could with my studies… the mockery ceased but the hostility remained."
- **Leaving things behind** (33:52–33:59): "first thing I did on leaving school was to break all ties, curse my past and shake the dust from off my feet."
- **Isolation at 24** (23:31–23:48): "my life even then was gloomy, ill regulated and as solitary as that of a savage."
- **The servant** (1:14:28–1:14:36): Apollon was "the bane of my life… I believed I had never hated anyone in my life as I hated him."

4. The intellectual

- **The "terribly intelligent face"** (24:20–24:28): "I would have put up [with] a [base] look if at the same time my face could have at least been thought strikingly intelligent."
- **Overthinking as illness** (6:40–6:48): "to be too conscious is an illness… every sort of consciousness is in fact a disease."
- **Intelligence as an excuse for futility** (4:52–5:00): "an intelligent man cannot become anything seriously, and it's only the fool who becomes anything."

5. Character: no stable self, petty malice, fear and shame

- **No stable identity** (4:37–4:45): "I did not know how to become anything: neither spiteful nor kind, neither a rascal nor an honest man, neither a hero nor an insect."

- **Can't even be lazy** (12:58–13:24): "if only I'd done nothing simply from laziness… I should at least have been capable of being lazy… Question: what is he? Answer: a sluggard… it would mean I was positively defined."
- **Malice as recreation.** As an official (2:46–2:55) he "felt intense enjoyment whenever I succeeded in making anyone unhappy." He also admits (3:43–3:53) he was "simply scaring sparrows at random."
- **The barb at the dinner** (42:03–42:11): "and yet this Prince Kolya who has three thousand serfs has not put in an appearance here tonight to see you off, has he?"
- **Fear and shame** (24:37–24:44): "I was fearfully afraid of being seen, of being met, of being recognized."
- **Superior yet insignificant** (24:51–25:10): "a nasty disgusting fly, more intelligent, more highly developed, more refined in feeling than any of them of course, but a fly continually making way for everyone."

6. Vice, dreaming, and the sublime and beautiful

- **Sinking deeper the more he sees the good** (7:13–7:20): "the more conscious I was of goodness and all that was sublime and beautiful, the more deeply I sank into my mire."
- **The grandiose daydream** (25:18–25:56): "I was triumphant over everyone… I forgave them all. I was a poet and a grand gentleman, I fell in love, I came in for countless millions and immediately devoted them to humanity… I confess before all the people my shameful deeds, which were of course not merely shameful but sublime and beautiful… I should go barefoot and hungry preaching new ideas."
- **Dream, then craving for society** (26:04–26:12): "more than three months of dreaming… an irresistible desire to plunge back into society."
- **Dreaming himself Liza's hero**, where love turns into being loved (1:13:19–1:13:49): "I become the salvation of Liza… she flings herself at my feet and says that I am her Savior."
- *Not in Cedar:* the reading passage, the "sauce," and "hero or wallow in the mud."

7. Love

- **Love as domination** (1:24:57–1:25:27): "loving meant showing my moral superiority… love really consists in the right freely given by the beloved object to tyrannize over her… I did not imagine love except as a struggle. I began it always with hatred and ended it with moral subjugation."
- **He can still recognize real love** (1:25:27–1:25:41): "she had come not to hear fine sentiments but to love me."
- **The sermon as power, not care.** First admitted at 1:08:39–1:08:46 ("it was the exercise of my skill that carried me away"), then said to her face (1:21:21–1:21:29): "power, power was what I wanted then… I wanted to wring out your tears, your humiliation."
- **Liza's need to be respected.** The student's letter (1:11:03–1:11:11) is proof "that she too was honestly and genuinely loved."
- *Not in Cedar:* the bullied school friend.

For discussion: The sermon to Liza (59:16–1:08:46) is persuasive and partly true. Does its purpose (power) change what it is?

8. Integration: ideal vs. reality

- **Real life as oppression** (1:26:01–1:26:08): "I wanted peace, just to be left alone in my underground world; this real life oppressed me so much I could hardly breathe."
- **Better in books** (1:29:15–1:29:31): "we're all divorced from life… we've come almost [to look] upon real life as an effort, as hard work, and we're all privately agreed that it's better in books."
- **Knows the underground isn't the answer** (21:06–21:14): "it is not the underground which is better, but something different, quite different, for which I am searching but which I cannot find."

9. Is this the human condition?

- **He claims it is, and that he's just more honest** (1:30:18–1:30:26): "I have only in my life carried to an extreme what you have not dared to carry halfway, and what's more you've taken your cowardice for good sense."
- The lecturer disagrees: this is one common *response* to the gap between ideals and reality, not the human condition as such.

For discussion: Who's right, the Underground Man or the lecturer?

10. Pleasure in degradation

- **Bitterness turning to sweetness** (7:35–8:07): "a sort of secret, abnormal, despicable enjoyment… until at last the bitterness turned into a sort of shameful accursed sweetness, and at last into positive real enjoyment."
- **The slap in the face** (9:10–9:27): "if I happen to be slapped in the face I should probably have been able to discover even in that a peculiar sense of enjoyment, the enjoyment of course of despair."

11. Revenge

The stone wall and man-of-action passage is not in Cedar. Instead, the performance *acts out* the intellectual's indirect, stalled revenge.

- **The toothache: suffering used as passive aggression** (11:18–11:36): "I'm worrying you, I'm lacerating your hearts… keeping everyone in the house awake. Well, stay awake then."
- **The 18-month feud over a sword** (3:11–3:26): "I carried on a feud with him for some 18 months over that sword… at last I got the better of him… he left off clanking it."
- **The revenge fantasy** (50:36–50:45): "the initiative will be mine and by the laws of honor that is everything." It spirals into imagining Siberia and forgiveness (52:35–53:11): "I have come to discharge my pistol and… I forgive you."
- **Can't follow through, and is relieved.** He first stops the sledge in shame (53:21–53:28). Finding no one there (54:38): "I felt as though I'd been saved from death."
- **Revenge redirected onto Liza** (1:20:42–1:21:05): "I had to avenge the insult on someone… you turned up, I vented my spleen on you… I had been humiliated, so I wanted to humiliate."
- **Petty power over Apollon** (1:15:58–1:16:07): withholding his wages "to show him that if I liked I [could] withhold his wages because I was the master."

12. Being rational: the Enlightenment argument

- **The argument laid out** (13:41–14:12): "who was it first proclaimed that man only does nasty things because he does not know his own interests… consequently, so to say, through necessity he would begin doing good." Then the mockery: "The babe! Oh, the pure innocent [child]!"
- **Problem 1: do we act only from self-interest?** (14:26–14:57): "when in all these thousands of years has there been a time when man acted only from his own interest?… man everywhere at all times… has preferred to act as he chose and not in the least as his reason and advantage dictated."
- **Problem 2: who defines a person's interest?** (19:03–19:32): "you want to cure men of their old habits and reform their will in accordance with science and good sense. But how do you know… that it is desirable to reform man in that way?"
- **Problem 3: interest in something harmful** (19:41–20:12): "perhaps suffering is just as great a benefit to him as well-being… it is sometimes very pleasant to smash things." *(The Civil War and bloodshed example is not in Cedar.)*
- **Reason as a fraction of life** (15:35–16:08): "reason… satisfies only the rational side of man's nature, while will is a manifestation of the whole life… it is life and not simply extracting square roots… not simply one-twentieth of my capacity for life."
- **Desire vs. reason is also useful** (17:21–17:44): "choice… is utterly and stubbornly opposed to reason, and… this too is profitable and sometimes even praiseworthy."

- **The "most advantageous advantage"** (16:51–17:21): "one man may consciously, purposely desire what is injurious to himself… simply in order to have the right to desire for himself even what is very stupid… for it preserves for him what is most precious… his individuality."
- **Independent choice at any cost** (15:11–15:20): "what man wants is simply independent choice, whatever that independence may cost and wherever it may lead."

13. The Crystal Palace: substitutes in Cedar

Cedar cuts the Crystal Palace, but two passages carry the same idea and speak directly to the course's theme.

- **Piano keys** (18:22–18:54): even if science proved man a piano key, "he would purposely contrive some destruction, some chaos… for the whole work of man really seems to consist in proving to himself every minute that he is a man and not a piano key."
- **Begging to be controlled again** (1:29:45–1:30:02): "give any one of us… a little more independence, untie our hands, widen the spheres of our activity, relax the control, and we… should be begging to be under control again at once."

For discussion: These two passages hold both halves of the defiance-vs.-control tension: the insistence on not being a piano key, and the admission that freedom is unbearable. Which one wins in the story?